

Protected Areas, WPA & Species

National Parks, Wildlife Sanctuaries, Biosphere Reserves and Wildlife Protection Act.

Portion focus ~50% · Topic: env-biodiversity

PYQ themes: Protected area categories · WPA schedules · Species habitats

Why UPSC asks this

Among highest Prelims environment weightage — map + law + species.

Category differences

Know legal/management differences among NP, WLS, Conservation Reserves, Community Reserves, Biosphere Reserves, Tiger Reserves overlays. Ramsar wetlands often co-asked.

Species & habitats

Match critically endangered/flagship species to landscapes (tiger landscapes, Gangetic dolphin, Great Indian Bustard, etc.). Invasive species and corridor ecology appear.

Law

WPA schedules; CITES awareness; Biodiversity Act institutions (NBA) at outline level.

Map / list facts

- Hotspots: Western Ghats, Indo-Burma, Himalaya, Sundaland (Nicobar) — as commonly listed for India-related hotspots

Must remember

- NP > WLS in restriction intensity (textbook contrast)
- Biosphere Reserve — core/buffer/transition
- WPA 1972 schedules protect species at graded levels

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